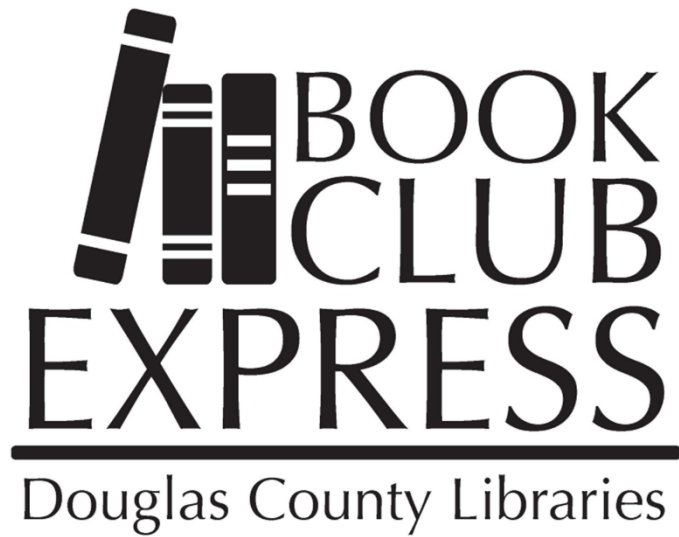




The Bletchley Riddle by Ruta Sepetys & Steve Sheinkin

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Discussion Questions

1. In chapter 2, we are introduced to Lizzie, who immediately declares, “Allow me to explain something. I’m lying.” How do you trust a narrator who tells you that she’s lying? In what ways does Lizzie lie to people in the story?
2. Gran always calls our heroine by her given name—Elizabeth—proclaiming, “Nicknames such as ‘Lizzie’ are reserved for barmaids and axe murderers, of which you are neither.” What’s the difference between the names Elizabeth and Lizzie? Why does Gran react so strongly to Lizzie’s preference? Do you have nicknames you prefer or dislike?
3. Presented with the same information, Jakob and Lizzie come to different conclusions about their mother’s fate. In the beginning of the book, are they more alike or different? How is this a source of conflict for the two of them? Does the relationship between Jakob and Lizzie change during the course of the novel? Give examples.
4. When Jakob and Lizzie return to the apartment in chapter 6, Lizzie finds Willa’s calendar diary under a loose floorboard. Think about your classroom or where you live. If you had to hide something important, what would you hide? Where might you stash your valuables?
5. In chapter 8, Lizzie and Jakob are boarding the train out of London. “I watch as they emerge, ghostlike, from the shadows, clutching gas masks and items most dear to them. Items they want to save from the Germans. A porcelain teapot. Leather-bound photo albums. A large brass menorah.” The reader infers that these items carry special significance. If you had to leave your home, what would you choose to bring?
6. The workers at Bletchley Park are assigned specialized tasks that keep the park compartmentalized. Why would government officials adopt this type of organization?
7. Jakob and Lizzie both sign the Official Secrets Act. Even though they are siblings, there are things they can’t share with each other. How do you feel when people are keeping secrets from you? What do you do about it? How do you stay friends? Would you sign the Official Secrets Act?
8. In chapter 9, Jakob introduces his sister to the guard, Reg Ribchester. This is the first of several unpleasant interactions between the two young men. How does Jakob and Reg’s relationship change over the course of the story?

9. In chapter 24, there is a strained interaction between Jarvis and Jakob when Jarvis says, "You're a Jew, Novis, aren't you?" How does Jakob respond? Can you identify other instances where Jakob had to confront anti-semitism?
10. In chapter 26, we learn that Jakob is a member of the Local Defense Volunteers. After his training session, several people make comments criticizing its members. For example, Mr. Berrycloth says of Jakob, "Busy playing games, he is. While the real men are off fighting Hitler." How does Jakob respond? Why doesn't he stand up for himself? Why do you think community members make fun of this group?
11. In chapter 27, when Lizzie is left alone, she takes the opportunity to look around Jakob's room, noting, "My finds were not illuminating. Tattered spy novels, texts on information theory and binary multipliers, and an old Polish-English dictionary. At this point, the most I can accuse my brother of is being incredibly dull." Examine the contents of your locker (or backpack or bedroom). Catalog the items you find and then look at your list. What would an outsider infer about you? Is there anything you would need to add or eliminate in order for your possessions to reflect who you hope to be?
12. In chapter 68, Jakob is surprised to learn that his father was "a remarkably gifted linguist" whose codebreaking work helped the Allies win World War 1. Jakob responds, "What else have I never suspected?" Think of the adults in your life. What do you know about them? How can you find out more?
13. The smoking scarecrow: Who is he? What makes him mysterious? To whom does he report?
14. In chapter 88, when bombs rain down on London, Jakob and Lizzie take refuge in a shelter. As Lizzie observes, "An explosion detonates nearby, shaking the basement. A baby cries. Mortar crumbles from the bricks and a hushed group of voices begin a chorus of 'God Save the King.'" If put in a similar situation today, what would people sing to keep their spirits up?
15. Gran is a woman we never meet. Instead, we learn about her from Jakob's and Lizzie's memories, as well as from Viola, Fleetwood, and Olivia. What are the common characteristics of Gran? What is she like? What does she enjoy? How might she spend her days?
16. In times of difficulty, many families have to make decisions that may upset their children, such as a move or a change in daily activities. Think about the adults in the story: Willa, Gran, the Colonel, Mrs. Tilbury. What decisions do they have to make? What might they be thinking about?

17. In chapter 90, Jakob notes, “If Hilter was hoping to break our spirit, to sow panic and despair, he must be sadly disappointed.” How do Londoners respond to the bombing? How do you imagine your neighborhood responding to a similar situation?
18. Government propaganda posters advise Londoners: “You will be told what to do when the invasion comes” and “Stay where you are.” Lizzie doesn’t follow these directions. Is it because she identifies as being half-American? How do you think people would respond to these instructions today?
19. In Part 3, Lizzie and Jakob discover that “goulash” is code for September 7. How did they make this connection? If you had to create a code to communicate with your family, what words might you use?
20. This book is about a brother and sister working together to solve a family mystery. The Bletchley Riddle is the result of the collaborative partnership between bestselling authors Ruta Sepetys and Steve Sheinkin. What other partnerships do we see in the book? What makes a great partner?

Author Interview

The Bletchley Riddle follows Jakob and Lizzie Novis as they find themselves at Bletchley Park, Britain's codebreaking factory.

"The Bletchley Riddle is told by a brother and sister who deal with their mother's puzzling disappearance in opposite ways. Full of humor, family, the basics of code breaking, and an actual WWII code-breaking site, Bletchley Park," said Stephanie Ledyard of Interabang Books in Dallas, Texas.

Here, Sepetys and Sheinkin discuss *The Bletchley Riddle* with *Bookselling This Week*.

Bookselling This Week: In past interviews, you've each talked about your individual writing processes, so I was curious to hear how challenging — or maybe not challenging — it was for you to adapt those processes and work together to build this.

Steve Sheinkin: Did people warn you, Ruta, that it was going to be really hard to collaborate with someone?

Ruta Sepetys: They did. I don't want to speak for Steve, but honestly, it was an incredibly joyful, fun experience. Not only that, but I grew a lot from this experience, working with Steve — who's this master of nonfiction — and learning from his process.

SS: I feel the same. It did exactly what people always say, which is to step out of your comfort zone and challenge yourself. I have this tried-and-true system that I use for my nonfiction, and it just wouldn't have worked for this. I had to think in a different way in terms of creating twists and turns in the story and really getting emotionally in the character, and it was uncomfortable, but no doubt it made me a better writer.

RS: I think it helped that we have a similar sense of humor and a similar work ethic. Steve and I both clock in in the morning and sort of keep office hours. It might have been harder if we worked on very different schedules. But because we had the same hours, it felt that we had constant access to one another.

SS: We would plan things out on these Zoom meetings. We didn't have a master outline, but we would see far enough ahead to each write a few chapters.

What I realized very quickly is that when Ruta said she was going to write the next chapter, she meant *today*. I didn't mean today, not at first. Getting started, for me, is always the hardest part. I want to think about it. I want to outline a little more. That was also going out of my comfort zone. No, don't outline it. Just write it. Write a draft *today*.

RS: It was because I was so excited. We'd have these epic zooms! I'm a pantsier, not a plotter, and all of a sudden, we would have what I thought was a detailed outline.

Steve's like, "No, it was like a beat sheet." But I thought, "My goodness, this is great. Now I know what I'm doing."

SS: It made it more fun. Fun is not usually a word I associate with writing. It's rewarding, but it's hard work. But this one, maybe because of that instant feedback and gratification, I thought, "Oh, I'm gonna see if I can make Ruta laugh with this chapter." That's, again, not typical of the toil. If I'm just sitting in this room for six months drafting something, I just don't get that.

BTW: I'd love to hear a little bit about the research for this book. Were there any details that you felt you needed to adhere to, or that you were compelled to stay true to? Was there something that you wanted to include but you weren't able to?

RS: Oh, we're such research nerds.

SS: We were such sticklers for history. That's actually another thing that I just didn't know. I mostly write narrative nonfiction, so I know I'm not going to make up anything. So what are the parameters for fiction? Some people said, "Well, just rearrange stuff at your pleasure, and make whatever you want happen. It's fiction." And that's not Ruta's approach, which I really respected. We really wanted to stick to the real events. Fortunately, you don't have to make anything up to create this incredibly high-stakes story.

Just to give an example, Winston Churchill visited Bletchley Park. We thought, "That would make such a great epilogue to the story!" But then we found out that was in 1941, so it wasn't in our timeline.

That was the kind of thing where people said, "So what? No one knows that — even people who know a lot about World War II."

And Ruta shook her head and said, "No way."

RS: No way. We're writing for young readers, and we want to spark their interests so they will research, but we also want to give them something that's as close to authentic as possible. So yeah, we were sticklers on that.

And we visited Bletchley Park! We flew to London and we scouted out locations where Lizzie and Jacob's apartment would be. Then we got on the train and went out to Buckinghamshire, just like they would have. We showed up at the small Bletchley train station and walked with our bags — we didn't get an Uber — just like the codebreakers would have.

SS: It was like walking back in time, and it struck both of us that this is how so many stories begin. So many stories begin with kids being whisked away to some magical (slightly scary at first) place, and that's what happened to our characters. They're whisked away, in this case, to this mansion that had this Wonka-like codebreaking factory.

You can really get that sense today. Of course, you'll see ads and new cars, but if you just focus on the mansion, and the little lake, and these huts that they recreated around the grounds, you really feel like you're walking back into 1940. That was really powerful. We had written a lot of it before, but we re-imagined all of it once we were there.

RS: When we walked in the mansion, it was like walking onto the set of a BBC drama. Everything is so perfectly preserved and every volunteer that we came upon had a certain niche of knowledge related to Bletchley, or a certain time period, or a particular codebreaker. Every bit of it was just magical.

We also explored the surrounding village to determine where these people would live. We worked with Dr. David Kenyon, who's the official research historian for Bletchley.

SS: When I meet people like that, I feel like a kid meeting a grown up. He's not even that much older than us — if at all — but he just looked so dapper. We quickly bonded, because we were obsessed with getting this stuff right.

We skipped all the obvious things because we'd read stacks of books about it. I think he appreciated that we wanted to know really, really specific things like, "Where was the pigeon loft?"

We were asking things like that just aren't in any book. "Can you show us exactly where?" "Where was the tennis court?" "Where was the hedge maze?" (They had a hedge maze!)

There are just a few people in the world who have thought about this more than us, and they were all there.

RS: Dr. Kenyon got just as excited as we were when we said, "Look, it's important to us to really incorporate some of the more underrepresented stories of Bletchley. Particularly the women." (It's estimated that at the end of the war, 75% of the workforce there were women.) He was very passionate, and it felt like he was grateful that we had done that research. Then he opened up and started sharing more interesting details.

For example, Steve had mentioned that Ian Fleming, the writer of James Bond, was there at Bletchley. Dr. Kenyon told us that Tolkien had been interviewed as a potential codebreaker. He told us of a roster that listed people who were interviewed or recruited, and next to Tolkien's

name, it said, “keen,” in parentheses. And we were trying to figure out, did that mean he was keen to be a codebreaker, or was that referring to the pronunciation of his name?

We're also very grateful to all of the authors of nonfiction who have written about the Battle of Britain and Bletchley, because our work stands on the shoulders of nonfiction. The author Michael Smith zoomed with us and helped us work through some plot points.

SS: That was incredibly valuable. Not only is he the unofficial expert of Bletchley history, he was an intelligence officer (as many great spy novelists throughout history have been). And it almost felt like giving us permission sometimes. We'd ask, “Could this really happen?” “Oh yeah, I could see that happening.” I think that gave me a lot of confidence when he said, “Yes, yes. Actually, that is clever. That could happen, definitely.”

RS: As you might imagine, there are people who have devoted many years of study to Bletchley, and I've seen some people say, “Oh, I thought I knew a lot, but these are some new details and I really enjoyed it.” Our British publisher presented the book to Bletchley Park, and they appreciate it and are excited. So it's just wonderful.

BTW: Some of the facts that were in fiction books I read as a kid, are the facts that still stick with me. So having everything in your book be factual, it's just very valuable.

RS: Thank you for saying that. I felt that today at one of the school visits that we did. We were sharing that the great codebreaker, Alan Turing, cashed in his life savings and put it into silver bars when it looked like German invasion was imminent. He buried them outside of Bletchley. Later, he wasn't able to find his treasure. This is an actual fact, and when we told the students that, you could see them realize, “Wait, the silver's still there.” They wanted to research that. And even as an adult, those are the points that I also really gravitate toward,

BTW: So, if I understand right, you each took one of the main characters and wrote those chapters?

SS: Yes, exactly. I think we fell into a kind of a sibling relationship pretty easily. We both have brothers and sisters, so we know what that's like. We broke up the story into parts. Ruta thinks we outlined everything, and I think we just made it up as we went along. The chapters are short, but we would each write specifically from our character's point of view and then pass it on.

BTW: Was there anything particularly challenging about each of your characters?

RS: For me, it was really important that I capture the voice of this character. I wanted it to come organically. It was challenging, but I listened to interviews of some of these females who worked at Bletchley Park. And I realized there was a precocious feeling. I mean, imagine you're working there at 14 years old and you've signed the Official Secrets Act — you are very

precocious. Trying to capture that voice was a little challenging, but once I heard her, then there she was.

SS: I think of myself as a creative writer, but this was creative in a different way. There was the obvious challenge of “All right, he has to be a codebreaker. He has to sound like he really does understand all this stuff.” (So he's essentially much smarter than I am in this way.) That's a challenge a lot of writers take on, but it's not something I had ever done.

But the biggest challenge, for me, was unexpected. Ruta and our editor, Chelsea, had some comments like, “I really want to know a little bit more about what he's *feeling*.” That's something that I just don't deal with all the time. In nonfiction, when you have that kind of source material it's great, but a lot of times you don't. In this case, it's up to me to make it up. It has to feel right and real for this person.

RS: Steve really had the herculean task because he was writing the codebreaker and had to present the information about codes, and ciphers, and how the actual Enigma machine works in a way that a young reader not only can grasp it, but get excited about.

That is *really* hard. And then we're saying, “Oh, great, and what's he feeling?”

Steve, I bet sometimes you were like, “Look, he's feeling like he needs to win the war.” Yet he managed to do it all!

For me, it was a bit of an exercise in vulnerability. In the beginning, it was like, “This is Steve Sheinkin!” But then along the way, we began to edit each other. Then Steve would say, “Okay, here. Put this into Lizzie speak.” And in one of my chapters, I would say, “How would Jacob say this?”

So we did go into each other's chapters. I loved that. I thought that that really benefited the book in general.

BTW: That is so cool. Any idea what you will be working on next, either together or separately?

SS: I know the next thing. I have a couple graphic novels that are being drawn right now, and that takes a very long time. It's just a huge job. The next thing that will come out is my next narrative nonfiction book, a middle grade Wild West crime story.

RS: And my next project, that I've been researching for years and years, is a YA novel about historical stigma. It's about millions of innocent human beings who became prisoners of prejudice because they were diagnosed with a disease that was thought to be very contagious. They were exiled to remote islands because they had Hansen's disease, which we later realized is not as contagious as everyone thought.

BTW: Those both sound very exciting. I have one more question. Would you tell us a little bit about the role of books and indie bookstores in your life?

RS: My career as an author was built by indie bookstores, teachers, and librarians working together. Meeting indie booksellers who then arranged school visits for me helped me build relationships with teachers and librarians. They handsold my books to their customers who they knew had a cultural connection or personal interest in these topics. It's such a foundational element of my entire career.

SS: Same. I mean, I've gotten good at sitting in this room and writing, but that's doesn't get you a career, because no one would necessarily know. It's because of librarians or booksellers who make those connections and think, "Oh, I know who might like this kind of book."

Retrieved from American Booksellers Association's interview.

<https://www.bookweb.org/news/qa-ruta-sepetys-and-steve-sheinkin-authors-novemberdecember-kids%E2%80%99-indie-next-list-top-pick-%E2%80%9C>

Author Biographies

Ruta Sepetys

Ruta Sepetys (Rūta Šepetys) is an internationally acclaimed, #1 *New York Times* bestselling author of historical fiction published in over sixty countries and forty languages. Considered a “crossover” novelist, her books are read by both students and adults worldwide. Winner of the Carnegie Medal and honored by the American Academy of Arts and Letters, Ruta is renowned for giving voice to underrepresented history and those who experienced it. Her books have won or been shortlisted for more than fifty book prizes, appear on over forty state reading lists, and are currently in development for film and television.

Ruta is the daughter of a Lithuanian refugee. Born in Michigan, she was raised in a family of artists, readers, and music lovers. She is passionate about the power of history to foster dialogue and global understanding. Her research and writing on human resilience have earned her invitations to speak at NATO, European Parliament, the U.S. Capitol, the Library of Congress, and Embassies worldwide. She has been awarded fellowships from The University of Oxford in England and The Rockefeller Foundation’s Bellagio Center in Italy. *The New York Times Book Review* declared, “Ruta Sepetys acts as champion of the interstitial people so often ignored—whole populations lost in the cracks of history.”

Ruta was bestowed the Cross of the Knight of the Order by the President of Lithuania for her contributions to education and memory preservation and was honored with a postage stamp containing her image. She is deeply grateful for her Baltic heritage— even if it means she has a name that no one can pronounce.

Ruta lives with her family in the hills of Tennessee.

Steve Sheinkin

The short bio: A former textbook writer, Steve Sheinkin is now making amends by writing books young people might actually want to read. He's the author of fast-paced, cinematic nonfiction including *Diamond Fever*, *Bomb*, *Fallout*, *Undefeated*, *Born to Fly*, *The Port Chicago 50*, and *Impossible Escape*, as well as *The Bletchley Riddle*, a middle grade historical mystery written with Ruta Sepetys. Steve's accolades include a Newbery Honor, three Boston Globe-Horn Book Awards, a Sibert Medal and Honor, three National Book Award finalist honors, and the Margaret A. Edwards Award. He lives with his family in Saratoga Springs, New York.

And now for a bit more detail...

Check out his about page <https://www.stevesheinkin.com/about>

Reviews

"Two powerhouse authors collaborate on an enormously entertaining, expertly researched WWII novel with broad appeal...The authors successfully blend genuine suspense, sibling relationship issues, and humorous hijinks to create a tone both heartfelt and playful...Perfect for fans of Alan Gratz, this is an excellent fictional companion to Candace Fleming's *The Enigma Girls* (2024)...Both masters of their craft, Sepetys and Sheinkin's collaboration will draw fiction and nonfiction fans, not to mention a code-breaking coterie."—STARRED REVIEW, Booklist

"Swift, snappy, and suspenseful storytelling."—STARRED REVIEW, Publishers Weekly

"An impressive joint effort between Sepetys and Sheinkin . . . With broad appeal to both WWII and mystery enthusiasts, this highly recommended title is a first purchase for all libraries serving tweens and teens."—STARRED REVIEW, School Library Journal

"A master class in suspense...With its expert pacing and characterization and its careful delineation of historical and family stories, this is historical fiction at its best."—STARRED REVIEW, The Horn Book

"In a gripping and surprisingly funny World War II historical novel, siblings at a top-secret cryptography center break codes and investigate their mother's purported death in a bombing raid...This middle-grade novel is sure to transcend age ranges and is both mystery and historical fiction, with a healthy dose of adventure and the tiniest hint of young romance."—STARRED REVIEW, Shelf Awareness

"Brilliantly narrated from alternating points of view — Sheinkin writing Jakob's chapters, Sepetys writing Lizzie's — this suspenseful novel, perfect for both middle grade and young adult readers, takes us on the ride of a lifetime, spotlighting the power of family relationships in a world torn apart by war."—Laurie Halse Anderson, *The New York Times*

"A rich, enthralling historical mystery that engages and educates."—Kirkus Reviews

"Part mystery, part history, this book by two award-winning authors is a page-turner."—The Washington Post

"With genuine emotion and a richly developed historical setting, this has all the hallmarks of cowriters Sepetys and Sheinkin, so fans of either author will be pleased here."—BCCB

"[This] formidable pair is sure to mesmerize middle grade readers with *The Bletchley Riddle*." — BookPage

"[A] suspenseful, informative wartime adventure for readers ages 10 and older." —The Wall Street Journal

"Sepetys and Sheinkin deftly weave the desperate urgency of the days before the Blitz with the real history of geniuses like Alan Turing who bent their brilliance to stop Hitler." —The Christian Science Monitor

"A truly enthralling and brilliantly researched novel about the famous codebreakers of Bletchley Park in WW2." —Books for Keeps

"I loved every single page of this book. The Bletchley Riddle is exquisite historical storytelling! I only wish I could read it again for the very first time." —Jennifer A. Nielsen, #1 New York Times Bestselling Author

"In The Bletchley Riddle, two of the absolute best writers in kid lit have come together to craft an amazing work of historical fiction. This book has adventure, excitement, humor, heroism, and heart set against a backdrop with the highest stakes imaginable." —James Ponti, New York Times bestselling author of City Spies

"Break out your Enigma machines! Sepetys and Sheinkin have written a thrilling World War II code-breaking adventure filled with ciphers, secrets, and spies." —Alan Gratz, New York Times bestselling author of Refugee

"Brilliant! A seamless collaboration produces a genius tale with incredible historical twists! I loved reading this book." —Kimberly Brubaker Bradley, author of The Night War

"Such a unique and amazing book! Sheinkin and Sepetys have layered impeccable research into a very readable, engaging story. I'm so happy that we will have this amazing adventure historical available for young readers. They clamor for books like this!" —Rae Ann Parker, Director of Books for Young Readers, Parnassus Books in Nashville

Read-Alikes

The Enigma Girls: How Ten Teenagers Broke Ciphers, Kept Secrets, and Helped Win World War II by Candace Fleming

"You are to report to Station X at Bletchley Park, Buckinghamshire, in four days time....That is all you need to know." This was the terse telegram hundreds of young women throughout the British Isles received in the spring of 1941, as World War II raged. As they arrived at Station X, a sprawling mansion in a state of disrepair surrounded by Spartan-looking huts with little chimneys coughing out thick smoke—these young people had no idea what kind of work they were stepping into. Who had recommended them? Why had they been chosen? Most would never learn all the answers to these questions.

Bletchley Park was a well-kept secret during World War II, operating under the code name Station X. The critical work of code-cracking Nazi missives that went on behind its closed doors could determine a victory or loss against Hitler's army. Amidst the brilliant cryptographers, flamboyant debutantes, and absent-minded professors working there, it was teenaged girls who kept Station X running. Some could do advanced math, while others spoke a second language. They ran the unwieldy bombe machines, made sense of wireless sound waves, and sorted the decoded messages. They were expected to excel in their fields and most importantly: know how to keep a secret.

Bomb: The Race to Build-and Steal-the World's Most Dangerous Weapon by Steve Sheinkin

In December of 1938, a chemist in a German laboratory made a shocking discovery: When placed next to radioactive material, a Uranium atom split in two. That simple discovery launched a scientific race that spanned three continents.

In Great Britain and the United States, Soviet spies worked their way into the scientific community; in Norway, a commando force slipped behind enemy lines to attack German heavy-water manufacturing; and deep in the desert, one brilliant group of scientists was hidden away at a remote site at Los Alamos. This is the story of the plotting, the risk-taking, the deceit, and genius that created the world's most formidable weapon. This is the story of the atomic bomb.

The War that Saved My Life by Kimberly Brubaker Bradley

Ten-year-old Ada has never left her one-room apartment. Her mother is too humiliated by Ada's twisted foot to let her outside. So when her little brother Jamie is shipped out of London to escape the war, Ada doesn't waste a minute—she sneaks out to join him.

So begins a new adventure for Ada, and for Susan Smith, the woman who is forced to take the

two kids in. As Ada teaches herself to ride a pony, learns to read, and watches for German spies, she begins to trust Susan—and Susan begins to love Ada and Jamie. But in the end, will their bond be enough to hold them together through wartime? Or will Ada and her brother fall back into the cruel hands of their mother?

Heroes: a novel of Pearl Harbor by Alan Gratz

December 6, 1941: Best friends Frank and Stanley have it good. With their dads stationed at the Pearl Harbor naval base in Hawaii, the boys get to soak up the sunshine while writing and drawing their own comic books. World War II might be raging overseas, but so far America has stayed out of the fight. There's nothing to fear, right?

December 7th, 1941: Everything implodes.

Frank and Stanley are touring a battleship when Japanese planes zoom overhead, dropping bomb after bomb. As explosions roar and sailors scream, Frank and Stanley realize the unthinkable is happening: Japan is attacking America! The war has come to them.

Frantically, the boys struggle to find safety. But disaster and danger are everywhere--from torpedoes underwater to bullets on the beach... to the shocking cruelty that their friends and neighbors show Stanley. Because his mom is Japanese-American, Stanley is suddenly seen as the "enemy." And Frank, who is white, cannot begin to understand what his friend is now facing.

If the boys make it through this infamous day, can their friendship--and their dreams--survive? Or has everything they know been destroyed?

Max in the House of Spies: A Tale of World War II by Adam Gidwitz

Max Bretzfeld doesn't want to move to London.

Leaving home is hard and Max is alone for the first time in his life. But not for long. Max is surprised to discover that he's been joined by two unexpected traveling companions, one on each shoulder, a kobold and a dybbuk named Berg and Stein.

Germany is becoming more and more dangerous for Jewish families, but Max is determined to find a way back home, and back to his parents. He has a plan to return to Berlin. It merely involves accomplishing the impossible: becoming a British spy.